

Roof over their HEADS

Eighty-nine families rendered homeless by the flooding of the Kosi have moved into new, safe houses built by CARE TODAY



A NEWLY BUILT HOUSE AT PURAINEE VILLAGE IN BIHAR'S SUPAUL DISTRICT

Immediately after the Kosi river breached its embankments on August 18, 2008, rendering millions homeless, CARE TODAY initiated the Bihar Flood Relief Fund to help and rehabilitate the flood-affected communities. Our appeal met with a generous response and Rs 1.43 crore was raised. In September 2008, CARE TODAY started relief work in the villages of Nawagachia subdivision of Bhagalpur district with a grant of Rs 5 lakh to an NGO, the Bihar Development Trust.

CARE TODAY also launched two simultaneous efforts for long-term rehabilitation of the poorest households. Under the first project, it joined hands with the sos Children's Villages for supporting rehabilitation efforts of 150 children and their families at Jorgama village in Madhepura district with a total commitment of Rs 25.2 lakh. In the second project, it had partnered with the Kutch Nav Nirman Abhiyan (KNNA), which functions as the secretariat of the Owner Driven Reconstruction Coalition, along with SEEDS, Hunnarshala Foundation, Unnati, and the Asian Coalition for Housing Rights. The Coalition is also supported by the United Nations Development Programme and the National Disaster Management Authority. As a part of the agreement, the KNNA received a grant of Rs 59.51 lakh to facilitate reconstruction of 89 houses in Puraanee village of Supaul district. Of the total amount,

CARE TODAY has so far spent Rs 89.71 lakh.

The owners were encouraged to recycle usable building materials and incorporate disaster risk reduction features in the newly built structures and, with active community participation, 89 houses were reconstructed, their total area measuring about 26,960 sq ft against the earlier envisaged 13,500 sq ft. The project has also been able to leverage resources to strengthen community infrastructure by establishing solar-powered street lights and lights in individual houses, construction of toilets and laying 20,000 sq ft of internal roads with brick soling. Currently, this approach is also being considered as a part of the larger reconstruction effort in flood-affected districts of Bihar.

On the other hand, the sos Children's Villages' Family Strengthening Project is progressing successfully and has recently been instrumental in sending 39 children to school. It has also been instrumental in providing financial support to initiate small business activities for 19 flood-affected families.

CARE TODAY was set up by the India Today Group in 1999 during the Kargil War to channelise financial contributions from readers to help the victims of conflict and calamities. Its varied projects over the last few years have rekindled hope among people and communities across the country.